Researching NGO feminism in Colombia, through political ethnography

RESEARCH PRESENTATION NOV. 6TH

STEOP COURSE INTRODUCTION TO POLITICAL SCIENCE

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PHD RESEARCH PRESENTATION

Connected to Prof. Dorit Geva's lectures

1) Interpretive Methods in Political Science

2) Feminist Approaches, Gender and Politics

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PHD RESEARCH ON
COLOMBIAN NGO FEMINISM

Ethnographic research through long-term immersive fieldwork in 2022 with a set of Colombian feminist non-governmental organizations (NGOs) working with different women groups around the country and with international funding from the global North (Europe, Canada, etc...)

1) Participant observation in office work, backstage meetings, and public events
2) Semi-directed interviews with feminists who work in these organizations

THE "NGOIZATION" OF FEMINISM (1)

The concept of "NGOization" of feminism was developped by Sabine Lang (1997) in her study of feminism in post-reunification Germany:

- **Different political cultures and ideological divisions** between West and East Germany
- But a **common feature** during reunification: **lack of public presence and visibility of women activism**
- WHY? Emergence of a new **mode of feminist organizing** (more specialized, professionalized, and institutionalized), replacing more radical women's movement activism

THE "NGOIZATION" OF FEMINISM (2)

It became popular to describe common global trends in the transformation of feminist activism across very different contexts:

Since the 1990s: well-established national and transnational non-governmental organizations addressing gender issues and women's empowerment more visible than feminism as a social movement, in the context of globalization

Very different from radical movement activism of the second-wave feminism in the 1970s loosely organized in self-organized anti-hierarchical collective focused on broad cultural transformation that did not want to interact with state institutions (radical feminism)

THE "NGOIZATION" OF FEMINISM (3)

The concept of NGOization suggests a form of "depoliticization" of feminism: the scope and nature of political intervention was restricted from contestation to participation; from activist action to policy expertise, and funded projects; from antagonism to collaboration with state institutions.

In Latin America: feminists working with the state or with NGOs were accused of being "traitors" of the feminist movement in the Regional Feminist Encounters in the 1990s by self-proclaimed "autonomous" feminists

Strong class and race divisions among women between NGO workers mostly white, educated, professional women from urban centers, and impoverished, Afro-descendant, or indigenous women, from marginalized rural territories connected to other political struggles

LIMITS OF THE CONCEPT OF NGOIZATION

- The concept of NGOization relies on a binary opposition (good movements vs. bad NGOs) and idealized assumptions of past feminist as properly political.
- It does not capture the complex and messy reality of feminist NGO work and organization.
- Sonia Alvarez (1990) nuanced the NGOization critique in Latin America, where feminist NGOs have done crucial "movement work" in the context of democratization (producing knowledge, disseminating discourses, channeling resources, articulating platforms, alliances, and coalitions...) and should be conceived as "hybrid political formations" between state institutions and popular movements

STUDYING NGO FEMINISM, THROUGH INTERPRETIVE METHODS

- The NGOization debate is an example of political debates that animate feminism: is working with institutions to obtain gradual changed is the appropriate strategy? (liberal vs. radical feminist approaches)
- Feminist debates are not purely abstract discussion of ideas, interests, and strategies; they are rooted concretely in embodied identities, experiences, emotions of different feminist subjects
- To study such debates (as political scientists), we need interpretive methods that unpack the different meanings and purposes that the feminist political project has for different actors in different contexts

POLITICAL ETHNOGRAPHY AS INTERPRETIVE METHODS

Two ingredients:

1) a methods of immersion in a community (knowing from inside)

2) an approach sensible to meanings that people attribute to their social reality

What we gain:

-flesh out general debates with detailed empirical stories about real life

-possibility of conceptual innovation

-broad understanding of politics, beyond formal institutions

Ethnographic Fieldnotes, from April 2022 (1)

We will now look together at an example of ethnographic fieldnotes from my fieldwork in Colombia and try to interpret it together, in light of the NGOization debate.

Ethnographic Fieldnotes, from April 2022 (1)

"Together with feminist NGO workers from Spain and from Bogotá (capital city of Colombia), I am in Montes de María, on the Caribbean coast, on a fieldtrip to follow-up a joint NGO project. Montes de María has also been an epicenter of the Colombian armed conflict. Massacres, forced displacement, and sexual violence have left deep scars on this marginalized territory, exploited for its agricultural resources, and abandoned by the Colombian state.

More than one hundred indigenous, afro-descendant, and rural women from all over the region have gathered, upon the invitation of a feminist NGO from Bogotá. Representatives from other national and transnational NGOs and international organizations are also here. The atmosphere is not as formal and up-tight as other NGO events I attended in Bogotá so far; it is loaded emotionally with collective enthusiasm but also with fear; the last days have been stressful in the town. A police officer was killed by criminal actors. The atmosphere is tensed, people fear an escalation of violence between armed actors. At the same time, this big group women have gathered for another reason today. There is something to celebrate.

Ethnographic Fieldnotes, from April 2022 (2)

Jimena, an indigenous woman from the region is the host for the NGO event. After the customary round of formal greetings and acknowledgments to the institutions that funded the project and event, she switches tone and exclaims: “We gave birth, women, and this fills us with great joy. We hope that you can cherish our child”.

But Jimena is not actually talking about a human birth here. Women gathered that day for the launch of a women’s human rights report, produced collaboratively between a group of women from the region and a Colombian feminist NGO from Bogotá. The human rights report, a policy document, is presented as the child for all the women of the region. The launch of the report is presented a collective experience of giving birth, after long embodied labor, with all the hope and excitement that a new life brings to the community."

INTEPRETATION

Discuss in groups of 2/3 students:

- What do these fieldnotes show? What is the meaning of NGO feminist work in this context?
- Is the concept of NGOization useful to analyze what is happening in this ethnographic picture?

INTEPRETATION

What fieldnotes shows:

- The work of writing a women's rights report was not interpreted on the ground as a purely "depoliticized", "professionalized" or "technical" form of feminism (what the NGOization concept suggests)
- Here, indigenous, afro, and rural women from a marginalized region of Colombia compared their participation in feminist NGO work to their care labor (=all the work that women do to sustain biological and social life), writing a report was associated with giving birth to a child, as a fruit of their labor

ANALISIS

The contribution of my PhD research is to move beyond the critique of professionalized feminist work, towards the analysis of NGO feminism as a field of labor

- Professionalized NGO work should not be analyzed as a "depoliticized" field
- Instead, I suggest to focus on the various forms of "labor" that different women do (professional/paid but also activist/unpaid)
- With Marxist-feminist approaches of labor (not just "work") we can highlight that these various forms of labor are not all equally compensated and recognized as such
- In our ethnographic example: with their comparison, grassroots women make their own labor visible in the NGO setting. However, their labor is still not valorized materially in the same way as the paid work of NGO professionals.